

# CLEVER GIRL INVESTOR: MEET JULLY-ALMA TAVERAS

Jully-Alma Taveras is the founder of Investing Latina (@investinglatina). She started investing as a teenager, made several money mistakes, and then dug herself out of five-figure consumer debt. Now, her mission is to educate others about financial literacy and investing. Her biggest financial accomplishment is investing early with just \$50.

**Q. You are a huge advocate for women and investing. What's your personal story and how did you get started with investing?**

A. I started investing when I was 19 years old, right around the time of the historic 2008 recession. While I was in fashion school, I took on a job at a nonprofit organization that focused on providing services to seniors in need. When I sat in the HR meeting to go over the benefits, they highlighted the 403(b) retirement plan and emphasized that they provided a dollar-for-dollar match. All I heard was “free money” and I immediately signed up. I actually made my very first investing mistake two and a half years later; I left the company prior to having the company match vested. This meant that I lost \$6,000 of “free money.” Now I make a point to always ask when my employer contributions will be fully vested when I start a new job. Big tip for all of you reading this book!

**Q. What were your fears around investing and how did you deal with them?**

A. Although I didn't have much fear when it came to my 403(b) and 401(k) investments, I became fearful when I was ready to open up my personal brokerage account. I felt a sense of security and comfort with an employer-sponsored account that was actively managed and I trusted was in good hands. But for some reason I was crippled when it came to opening my own personal account. I thought, “What if I mess this up really badly? What if I lose all my hard-earned money?” I was scared, but decided to do it anyway. I realized that if millions of people are investing in the stock market and earning money, then those millions of people cannot all be wrong. If I wanted to build wealth and do something powerful with my earnings, I had no choice but to join in and invest in the market.